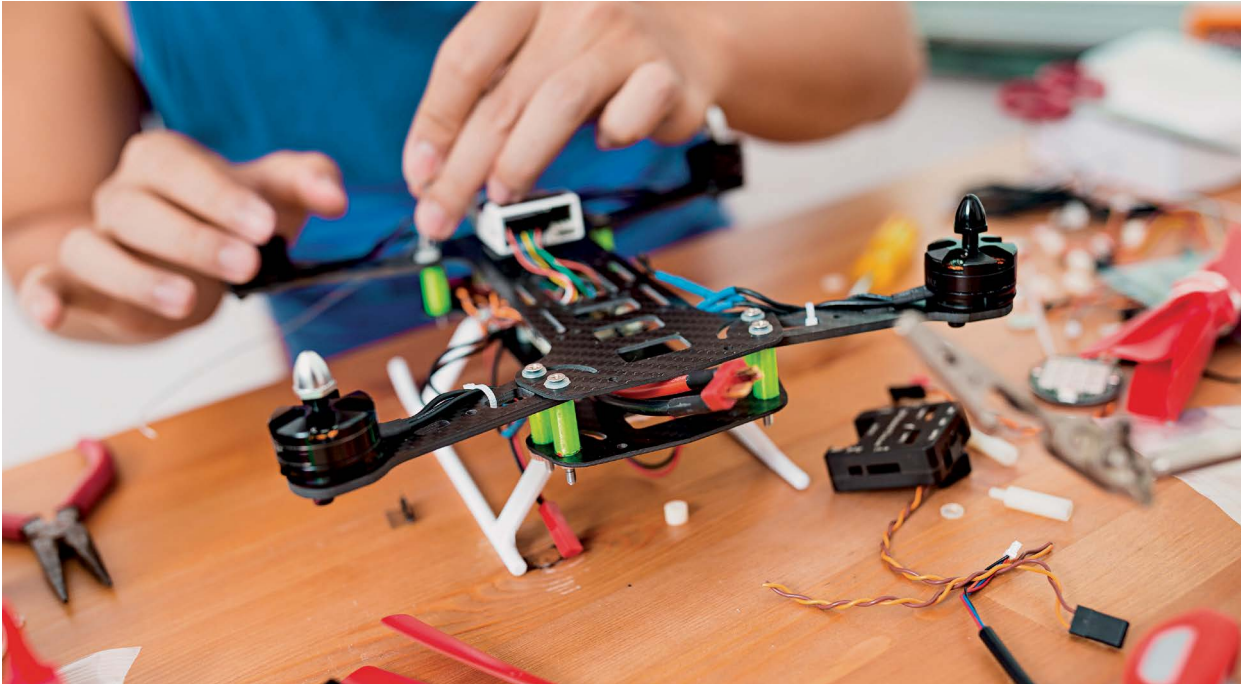




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DRONES

Flying High

News of Google looking to set up a drone manufacturing facility in India has got the domestic industry's hopes soaring

BY SUDESHNA MITRA

► **A MEETING BETWEEN** officials of Google's parent Alphabet and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin came as a shot in the arm for Indian drone manufacturers. Reports suggest that the tech giant is planning to set up a factory in the southern state to manufacture drones.

The Indian government's efforts to give the industry a boost appear to be bearing fruit. In 2021, the government announced a subsidy of ₹120 crore under the Production-Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for

the manufacturers of drones and their components. Then, in the Interim Budget 2024–25 presented earlier this year, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman increased the outlay for the sector under the PLI scheme to ₹57 crore from ₹33 crore the previous year.

In 2022, then Union Information and Broadcasting Minister Anurag Singh Thakur had said that India aims to become a global leader in drone manufacturing. Flagging off the Drone Yatra 2.0—an initiative

to send drones to villages to apply pesticides to farms—he had said the country would require at least 100,000 drone pilots by 2023. Subsequently, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) recognised 63 remote pilot training organisations in 2023.

But is the sector keeping pace with the government's ambitions?

Data from research firm Tracxn shows there are 384 drone start-ups in India. The list includes ideaForge (India's first listed drone manufacturer), Newspace Research and Technologies, Garuda Aerospace, Marut Drones, and General Aeronautics. A separate study by data platform Statista estimated that Indian drone companies would generate revenues of ₹225 crore in 2024, against world leader China's ₹12,740 crore.

Clearly, India is far behind in the drone manufacturing race and certainly far away from its goal to be among the world leaders. Can Google's entry change this scenario?

"The entry of a tech giant is